

2.6. Urban settlements

The census of India, 1991 defines urban settlements as "All places which have municipality, corporation, cantonment board or notified town area committee and have a minimum population of 5000 persons, at least 75 per cent of male workers are engaged in non-agricultural pursuits and a density of population of at least 400 persons per square kilometers are urban settlements.

Evolution of Urban Settlements

The first urban settlement to reach a population of one million was the city of London by around A.D. 1810. By 1982 approximately 175 cities in the world had crossed the one million population mark. Presently 48 per cent of the world's population lives in urban settlements compared to only 3 per cent in the year 1800.

Stages of Urban Settlements

Depending on the size and the services available and functions rendered, urban centers are designated as town, city, million city, conurbation, Megalopolis.

Town (Population more than 5000 people)

The concept of 'town' can best be understood with reference to 'village'. Population size is not the only criterion. Functional contrasts between towns and villages may not always be clear cut, but specific functions such as, manufacturing, retail and wholesale trade, and professional services exist in towns.

DO YOU KNOW?

Kraal is a group of houses surrounding an enclosure for livestock, or the social unit that inhabits these structures. The term has been more broadly used to describe the way of life associated with the kraal that is found among some African, especially South African, peoples. Kraal consists of a number of huts arranged in a circle around a cattle corral. Polygyny is common, and each wife has her own hut within the kraal. The head of the kraal may have custody of the property attached to the houses of his several wives.

City (Population more than 100,000)

A city may be regarded as a leading town. Cities are much larger than towns and have a greater number of economic functions. They tend to have transport terminals, major financial institutions and regional administrative offices. When the population crosses the one million mark it is designated as a million city.

Conurbation (Population of 2 or more cities combined)

The term conurbation was coined by Patrick Geddes in 1915 and applied to a large area of urban development that resulted from the merging of originally separated towns or cities. Greater London, Manchester, Chicago and Tokyo are examples. In India, Hyderabad and Cochin are the examples of conurbation cities.

Megalopolis (Population more than 10 million)

This Greek word "Megalopolis" meaning "great city", was popularized by Jean Gottman (1957) and signifies 'super- metropolitan' region extending, as union of conurbations. The urban landscape which stretches from Boston in the north to south of Washington in the U.S.A is the best known example of a megalopolis.

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